全民英檢中級 GEPT Intermediate | 第 44 單元 | 數量、大小與程度 · Quantity, Size & Degree

How Much Water Is in Your Lunch?

你的午餐裡有多少水？

Have you ever wondered how much water it takes to make your lunch? Most of us think only of the glass of water beside the plate, but that is barely the beginning. Scientists use the term "water footprint" to describe the total amount of water used to produce something, and the numbers are often enormous. A single hamburger, for example, requires an estimated 2,400 liters of water, which is roughly equivalent to forty full bathtubs. To a considerable extent, this water is used to grow the grain that feeds the cattle, not to cook the meat itself.

You can estimate your own water footprint in three simple steps. First, write down everything you eat on an average day, from the bunch of bananas at breakfast to the handful of candies after dinner. Second, look up the water footprint of each item on a reliable website; the gap between items may surprise you, since one cup of coffee uses about 130 liters while a cup of tea uses only 30. Third, add the numbers together. Do not worry about getting the total exactly right. Your goal is to understand the general size of your usage, not to produce a perfect figure.

Why does this matter? Taiwan receives heavy rainfall, yet its steep mountains let most of it flow quickly into the sea, so the island's capacity to store water is highly limited. During the extreme drought of 2021, several reservoirs were nearly empty, and the water supply in some cities was inadequate for weeks. Globally, about two billion people lack adequate drinking water. Fully understanding our footprint will not solve the problem overnight, but it can greatly change our choices. Eating slightly less meat, for instance, reduces a family's water use by a surprising amount. Small changes, when extended across millions of people, expand into something gigantic.

重點單字 Key Vocabulary

單字	詞性	中文	例句
barely	*adv.*	僅僅；幾乎不	He barely passed the math test. 他的數學考試勉強及格。
enormous	*adj.*	巨大的	The whale was enormous, longer than a bus. 那隻鯨魚非常巨大，比公車還長。

estimate	*v.*	估計；估算	We estimate that the trip will cost about NT$5,000. 我們估計這趟旅行大約要花五千元。
equivalent	*adj.*	相等的；等同的	One U.S. dollar is equivalent to about thirty NT dollars. 一美元大約相當於三十元新台幣。
considerable	*adj.*	相當大的；可觀的	The project took a considerable amount of time. 這個專案花了相當多的時間。
handful	*n.*	一把；少數	Only a handful of students stayed after class. 只有少數幾個學生下課後留下來。
gap	*n.*	差距；缺口	There is a big gap between the two teams' scores. 兩隊的分數有很大的差距。
capacity	*n.*	容量；能力	The stadium has a capacity of 40,000 people. 這座體育場可容納四萬人。
inadequate	*adj.*	不足的；不夠的	The food was inadequate for such a large group. 食物對這麼大的團體來說不夠。
gigantic	*adj.*	巨大的；龐大的	A gigantic balloon floated over the stadium. 一個巨大的氣球飄在體育場上空。

片語 Phrases

to a considerable extent	在相當程度上	The success was, to a considerable extent, due to luck. 這次成功在相當程度上是靠運氣。
look up	查閱；查詢	You can look up the word in the dictionary. 你可以在字典裡查這個字。
for instance	例如	Many fruits, for instance mangoes, grow well in Taiwan. 很多水果，例如芒果，在台灣長得很好。

文法與句型 Grammar

It takes + 數量 / 時間 + to + V

it 為虛主詞，take 表示「花費、需要」，後面接不定詞說明做某事需要多少時間或東西。

It takes about 2,400 liters of water to make one hamburger.

做一個漢堡大約需要 2,400 公升的水。

S + V ..., while + S + V

while 用來連接兩個互相對比的子句，意思是「而、然而」，強調兩者的不同。

A cup of coffee uses 130 liters, while a cup of tea uses only 30.

一杯咖啡用掉 130 公升的水，而一杯茶只用 30 公升。

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